June 2020 and May 2021, when sitting in Delhi's Rohini jail, he conned the wife of a jailed industrialist, creaming off more than Rs 200 crore from her. His modus operandi was a tried-and-tested one—posing as a senior government official over the phone, he would ask for money in return for a favour. To the jailed industrialist's wife, he pretended to be the Union law secretary, and took advantage of the pandemic to tell her that her husband was being considered for a place in a committee to fight Covid-19 and consequently for bail if she could contribute to party funds.

While investigating this case, law agencies stumbled on the fraudster's other penchant—lavishing gifts on film actresses. According to a chargesheet prepared by the Enforcement Directorate (ED), which is also probing him under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, he spent over Rs 7 crore between February 2021 and August 2021 on gifts for actress Jacqueline Fernandez and her family. The

Some call him a whizkid with the phone, others a polyglot and a smooth talker. He is also a great impersonator, affecting the voice of those that he wishes to pose as

agency believes the two had a romantic relationship, based on some intimate photographs. Jacqueline has denied the claim, but not Sukash. In a letter released to the media in December 2021, he disclosed, "I and Jacqueline were in a relationship, seeing each other, and the relationship was not based on any kind of monetary benefits like the way it's projected...the relationship has lots of love and respect for each other without any expectations." Around the same time, he allegedly tried to woo four other actresses—Nora Fatehi, Bhumi Pednekar, Sara Ali Khan and Janhvi Kapoor—but the ladies did not fall for his inducements (see *His Other Hits, and Misses*).

How did he pull it off? "He was a whizkid," says Karnataka IPS officer D. Devaraja, who headed the team investigating some of his early cases in 2011, speaking in almost admiring tones. "All he needed was a phone." The officials of the ED and the Delhi Police, who are dealing with him now, list two more skill sets that have helped him hoodwink politicians, businessmen and actors alike with ease—his smooth talking and command over several languages, be it English, Hindi, Tamil, Kannada, Telugu or Malayalam. He is said to be extremely persuasive and charming, as well as a great impersonator, adept at changing his voice and mannerisms to match the personality he chooses to pose as. He has not spared even the officers grilling him. "He sings like a bird during interrogation," says an ED officer. "He knows the loopholes of the legal system and tries to play mind games."

Who really is Sukash Chandrashekhar then? A compul-

THE Rs 200 CRORE HEIST

The ED chargesheet details how Sukash pulled the con

1 On June 15, 2020, Sukash Chandrashekhar, sitting in Delhi's Rohini Jail, first calls on the cellphone of Aditi Singh, wife of former Ranbaxy owner Shivinder Singh, lodged in Tihar Jail since 2019. Sukash uses a spoof app because of which the number displayed on Aditi's cellphone is one of those listed for the Union home ministry. Introducing himself as Union law secretary Anoop Kumar, he says he is calling on the instruction of the PMO. He tells Aditi that because of Shivinder's expertise in healthcare, the government wanted to include him in a top panel to be formed to fight Covid, and would therefore help the jailed businessman get out on bail soon.





Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE